was projected as a unifying symbol across caste divides to rally the proponents of reservation (OBCs and Dalits) as well as its opponents (upper castes) to the BJP's cause. 'The BJP model today is essentially an enlarged version and replication of that 1991 western UP formula: aspirational, upwardly mobile MBC [Most Backward Classes] aligning with BJP,' said Mrug. 'As their economic situation became better, it was better to scale up that experiment across UP … Amit Shah revived the old formula and the BJP went for it full on. They did social engineering with non-Jatavs and non-Yadavs. It was done deliberately, but the time for it was ripe anyway. Amit Shah was the right man at the right time for the BJP.'[8]

It is to this story, and how the new BJP transformed itself, that we now turn.